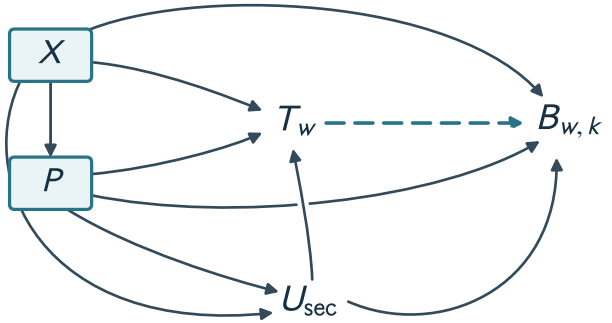
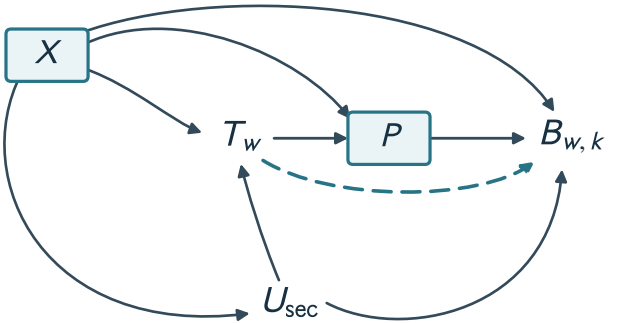
(i) P as a candidate confounder (reference)



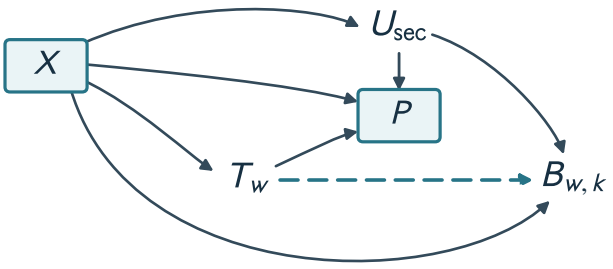
P is a hypothesized common cause of T_w and $B_{w,k}$.

(ii) P as a hypothetical mediator



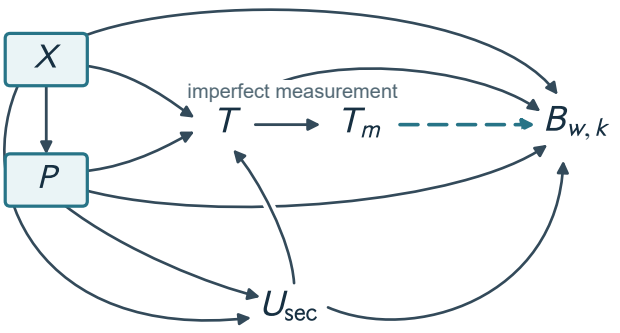
Conditioning may block part of the $T_w \rightarrow P \rightarrow B_{w,k}$ pathway.

(iii) Conditioned P as a collider



Conditioning may open the $T_w \leftrightarrow U_{sec} \rightarrow B_{w,k}$ path.

(iv) Potential measurement error in trust



T is latent/true trust; T_m is the trust measure used in the fitted models.

T_w = institutional trust in survey wave w; $B_{w,k}$ = protective behavior k in wave w; P = political leaning and ideology.
$X \subseteq C$ = measured baseline covariates; U_{sec} = unmeasured confounders (e.g., pandemic fatigue).
In panel (iv), T is latent/true trust and T_m is its imperfect single-item measurement; no direction of measurement-error bias is assumed.
The panels are alternatives the study cannot distinguish. All DAGs represent statistical associations;
absence of arrows does not establish independence or causal effects.